

Prompt engineering principles: Designing effective prompts

Best practice	What this means	Examples
Clarity	You should be very explicit about what you want the model to accomplish in the prompt. Stay clear of uncertainty.	Task: Translate a sentence from English to French. Unclear prompt: 'Translate this.' Effective prompt: 'Please translate the following English sentence into French: 'How are you today?''
Context matters	If you provide relevant context or background information in your instructions, the model's understanding and response accuracy will be significantly improved. It's like alerting your AI model a little in advance.	For example, it might help to include the source language when requesting an AI model to translate a sentence. 'Translate the following sentence from English to Hindi: [sentence]' gives the model the necessary background knowledge to translate the text accurately.
Mitigating bias	Biases in AI outcomes can be eliminated with the help of better prompt engineering. By providing clear and objective directions, developers can reduce the likelihood of delivering sensitive or biased information.	Use open-ended questions: Open-ended questions encourage models to explore content, provide comprehensive analysis without generating specific responses, and encourage exploration of various aspects of the prompt. Avoid any assumptions: Assumptions can lead to partial responses in models, such as the user's assumption that assistive robots are effective for dementia, causing a positive sentiment. Avoiding this assumption helps provide a less partial response in the second prompt. Use inclusive language: Inclusive language refers to language that does not discriminate against any particular group of people, such as 'humanity' instead of 'mankind'. Use multiple LLMs: Using multiple LLMs for response generation ensures a balanced and unbiased view, as no single LLM is perfect.
Specify output format		Less effective prompt: Extract the entities mentioned in the text below. Extract the following 4 entity types: company names, people names, specific topics, and themes. Effective prompt: Extract the important entities mentioned in the text below. First extract all company names, then extract all people names, then extract specific topics which fit the content. Desired format: Company names: <comma_separated_list_of_company_names> Text: {text}
Length matters	AI interfaces may have character counts, but extremely long prompts can be challenging for AI systems to handle.	To address these challenges, users can break down long prompts into smaller, more focused segments or provide clear and concise instructions to guide the model's response.
Avoid conflicting words or sentences	Prompts with ambiguous or contradictory terms, such as 'detailed' and 'summary', can cause conflicting information for the model. Prompt engineers ensure consistency in prompt formation.	Prompts should use positive language and avoid negative language, with a rule of thumb being 'do say 'do' and don't say 'don't'.' AI models are trained to perform specific tasks, so asking for an exception is meaningless unless compelling.
Cut down on 'fluffy' and vague descriptions	Prompts with vague words may produce incorrect results.	Less effective prompt: The description for this product should be fairly short, a few sentences only, and not too much more. Effective prompt: Use a 3 to 5 sentence paragraph to describe this product.